

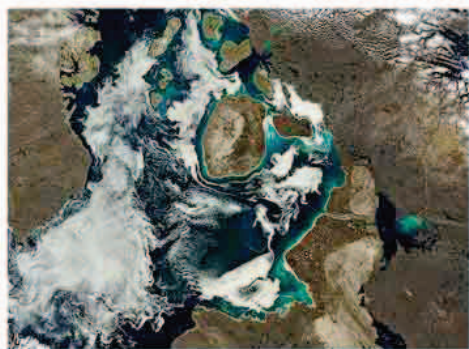
Arctic Ocean

Surrounded by North America, Europe, Asia, and Greenland, the Arctic Ocean is the smallest of the oceans. Its water is frozen over near the North Pole throughout the year, and the area covered by sea ice more than doubles in winter. But over recent years, the ice has been shrinking because of climate change.

FACT FILE

Area:	4,700,000 sq miles (12,173,000 sq km)
Average depth:	3,250 ft (990 m)
Deepest point:	18,400 ft (5,608 m)

Icy islands



▲ CHILLING DOWN

This satellite view shows sea ice forming around Prince Charles Island, Nunavut.

On the North American side of the ocean, the water is dotted with rocky islands. Along with part of the mainland, they form the Canadian territory of Nunavut. In winter, the sea between many of the islands freezes over, so they become part of a vast sheet of ice.

Melting seas



Climate change is warming the Arctic faster than anywhere else on Earth. It is making more of the sea ice melt in summer, opening up shipping routes that were previously blocked. Within 50 years, summers at the North Pole may be completely ice-free.

Moving target

The North Pole lies in the heart of the Arctic Ocean, in a region that is currently covered by sea ice throughout the year. Its position is indicated by a marker, but since the sea ice is constantly drifting with the currents at the rate of about 6 miles (10 km) a day, the marker is always being moved. In the future, melting ice at the North Pole may make placing the marker impossible.



► FROZEN OCEAN

The deep ocean basins in the heart of the Arctic Ocean are fringed by broad continental shelves and shallow seas. In winter, much of the ocean is a mass of drifting pack ice (pale blue).

